

An Art Form? Music, Media & Film

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Animated films can sometimes act as a mirror to better understand our selves. It can act as a lens helping us better understand the culture/world in which we live. Here are some questions that we can ask ourselves about any animated movie.

What is your favourite Animated Film?

My favorite animated film is 2007's *Surf's Up*. *Surf's Up* is a mockumentary-style animated film about Cody Maverick, a young penguin who dreams of becoming a pro surfer like his idol, Big Z. After traveling to Pen Gu Island for a major surfing competition, Cody gets humiliated. Then learns that surfing is about passion and joy and not fame. With guidance from an experienced mentor, Cody finds the true spirit of adventure and finds his own path.

What moments, character, or ideas resonated with you while watching this film? What about them?

The moments that resonated with me most were Cody's desire to be accepted, respected, and accomplished, which felt very relatable because he's not just trying to win, he's trying to find belonging. I also connected with Big Z as a mentor figure. His mix of wisdom, flaws, and past mistakes makes him a believably admirable and meaningful guide. Together, their stories highlight the importance of authenticity, supportive mentorship, and finding purpose beyond seeking approval from others.

Why did you connect with them?

Cody's story resonated with me because of his lack of a father, his strong pursuit of passion, and his dissatisfaction with the ordinary path. He isn't content to simply fall in line with what everyone else in his hometown does, he's drawn toward something bigger and more meaningful. His determination to carve out his own identity.

What is the primary or central theme of this film? Use one sentence to describe it.?

Existentialism; the reason I say that is because it tackles meaning, purpose, and where true fulfillment comes from, in way that is digestible for kids yet takes on deeper meaning as the viewer ages.

Describe any other themes that you see in the film's story.

Tank Evans's character is an archetypal representation of confidence turned into ego and competition becomes more important than connection. As the reigning champion, Tank is obsessed with winning and maintaining his image, using intimidation to mask his insecurities. he defines himself entirely by being "the best." While he's mostly played for comedy, Tank represents the darker side of ambition focusing so much on victory and status that you lose sight of the joy in the sport. highlighting how chasing approval can warp a person's values if they never slow down to find real meaning.

Many animated films explore important social or political issues. Describe any specific social or political issue/s that the film explored.

It subtly explores social issues related to pressure, identity, and the pursuit of recognition. The film highlights how communities can create rigid expectations, which reflects the real-world struggle many people face when trying to break out of social norms. It also touches on how fame and competition can distort values, shown through Tank and the commercialization of surfing culture. Additionally, Big Z's retreat from public life raises ideas about burnout, mental health, and the weight society places on public figures. While not overtly political, the film comments on how social environments shape ambition, self-worth, and the need for authentic connection.

Animated films can be persuasive. Did the film attempt to persuade viewers or promote any particular values or principles.

It uses its story and characters to promote several values and principles. The film encourages viewers to follow their passions rather than chase fame or external approval. Cody's story persuades us that genuine fulfillment comes from doing what you love, not from trophies or recognition. Big Z's arc reinforces the idea that stepping away from unhealthy competition and reconnecting with joy is more important than maintaining a public image. The film also promotes humility, mentorship, and community. Overall it persuades viewers to value authenticity, personal purpose, and supportive relationships over ego and status.

What thoughts did this filmsspur in you? What did it make you think about?

it really makes me reflect on the kind of life I want to lead and the goals I set for myself. It pushes me to think about where I want to set my aims. what achievements are truly meaningful versus what feels like chasing someone else's idea of success. The film highlighted that the value often lies in the journey itself, not just in winning. It made me consider what truly makes me tick, what excites me, drives me, and brings me fulfillment. Finally, it inspired thoughts about how I can seek adventure in my own life, embracing new experiences, challenges, and opportunities rather than sticking to a predictable path.